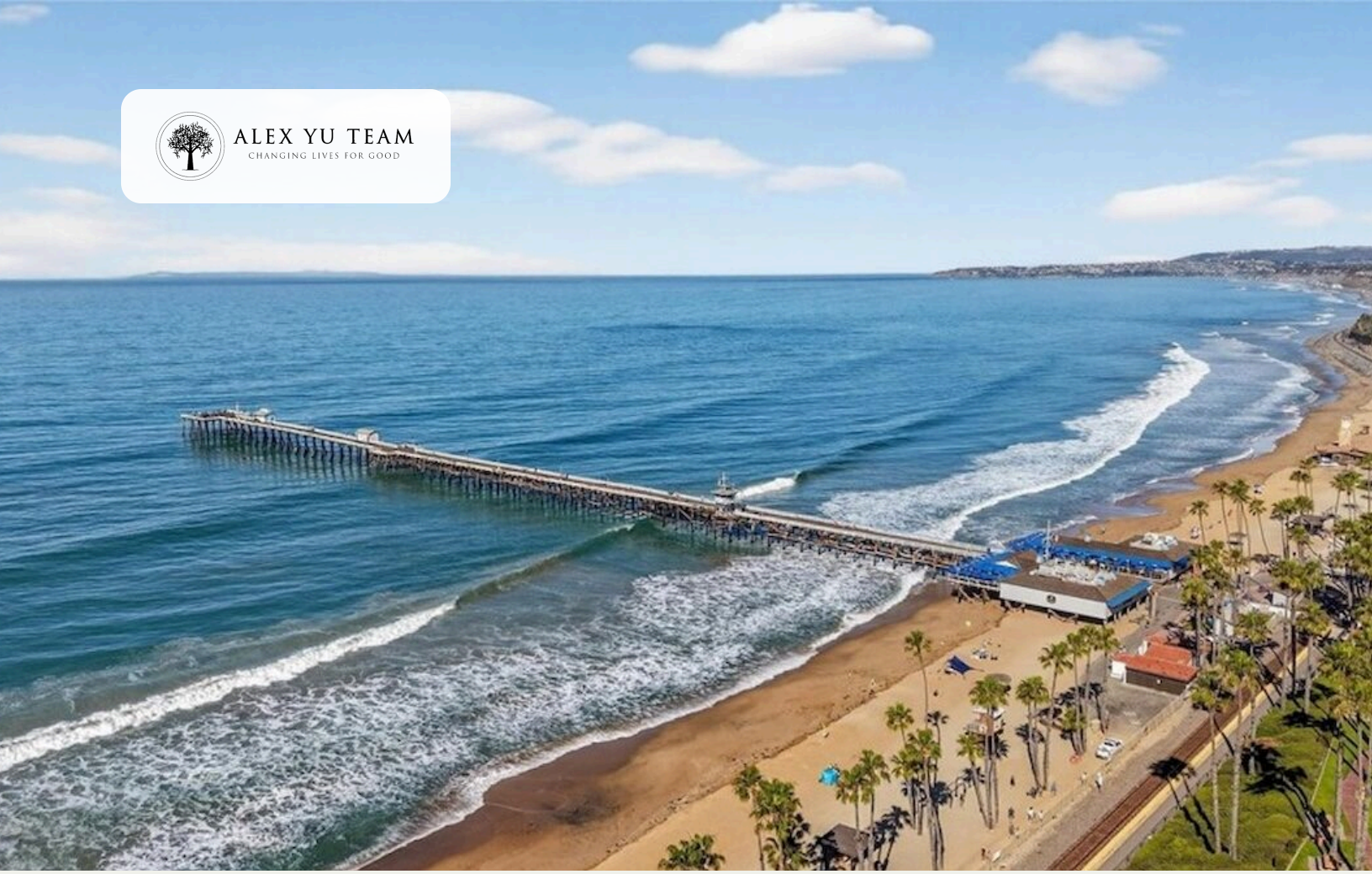


UPDATED OCTOBER 2026

The San Clemente Neighborhood Buyer's Guide

Six areas, side by side: what they are like, what to check and what to ask before you make an offer.

Prepared by Alex Yu of the Alex Yu Team · SERHANT · lifeinsanclemente.com

START HERE

How to use this guide

San Clemente is not one market. A short drive can take you from a walkable coastal village to a gated hilltop community to a large master-planned neighborhood, and the right answer changes by street. This guide puts the six main areas side by side, then gives you a short list of costs to price in and questions to ask on any home.

Everything here comes from public sources, listed on each neighborhood page at **lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods**. Figures change, so treat them as a starting point and confirm them for the exact home.

The six areas at a glance

Area	Character	Typical homes	Coast and walkability
Downtown & Pier Bowl	Walk to the beach	Spanish Colonial Revival cottages, older bungalows, and newer coastal builds	About 2.3 to 2.6 miles from North Beach to Calafia (sources differ)
Sea Summit	Newer coastal community	Newer single-family homes, many in a Spanish-style design with tile roofs	Coastal bluff, master-planned
Forster Ranch	Hillside, master-planned	Single-family homes on planned streets	Car-dependent (Redfin Walk Score about 11)
Shorecliffs	Beach club neighborhood	504, per the beach club's own history	Established coastal-side neighborhood
Talega	Master-planned, resort-style	Predominantly Spanish-Tuscan style	About 3 miles; about 2 miles east of I-5
Rancho San Clemente	Elevated hillside	Spanish-style single-family homes	Elevated, hillside, master-planned

Our focus. Single-family homes make up about 70% of San Clemente's inventory, and the median price is around $2 million. This guide is built around them.



WALK TO THE BEACH

Downtown & Pier Bowl

If you picture San Clemente as a Spanish village by the sea, this is the postcard. Avenida Del Mar runs through Downtown with red-tile rooflines and white stucco storefronts, and the Pier Bowl sits just below it, where the pier meets the sand.

Setting	Coastal, hillside, and walkable
Signature spots	San Clemente Pier, Avenida Del Mar, Casa Romantica
Pier history	Opened 1928, rebuilt in 1939 and 1983
Beach trail	About 2.3 to 2.6 miles from North Beach to Calafia (sources differ)
Getting around	San Clemente and San Clemente Pier train stations; I-5 nearby
Typical home style	Spanish Colonial Revival cottages, older bungalows, and newer coastal builds

What people like

- Walk to the pier, the beach, restaurants, and the Sunday farmers market
- Real architectural character along Avenida Del Mar
- Train stations in town for easy trips up or down the coast
- Sunset views that don't need a plane ticket

Worth knowing

- Summer weekends bring crowds, and beach parking gets tight
- Smaller lots and older homes can mean more maintenance
- Views and proximity to the water drive big price swings between streets

City parks nearby

These city parks are on or near the Downtown and Pier Bowl side of town.

Parque Del Mar (622 Avenida Del Mar) · **Linda Lane Park** (400 Linda Lane) · **Pico Park** (315 Avenida Pico)

Before you buy here, check: Parking; Age of systems; Permits.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/downtown-pier-bowl



NEWER COASTAL COMMUNITY

Sea Summit

Sea Summit sits on what locals know as Marblehead Coastal, one of the last big coastal parcels in Orange County to be built out. Instead of 1920s charm, you get modern floor plans, newer systems, and a planned layout.

Setting	Coastal bluff, master-planned
Built as	Four neighborhoods: Azure, Indigo, Aqua, Sapphire
Size	About 309 homes, per development announcements
Trail access	Sea Summit Trail runs along the cliffs
Typical home style	Newer single-family homes, many in a Spanish-style design with tile roofs
Ocean views	Vary lot by lot, from partial to wide-open

What people like

- Newer construction with Spanish-style design and modern layouts
- Cliffside trail access right nearby
- A planned community with consistent design
- Ocean views on many lots

Worth knowing

- HOA dues and community rules come with the territory
- View quality varies a lot between lots
- Less of the vintage character you find Downtown

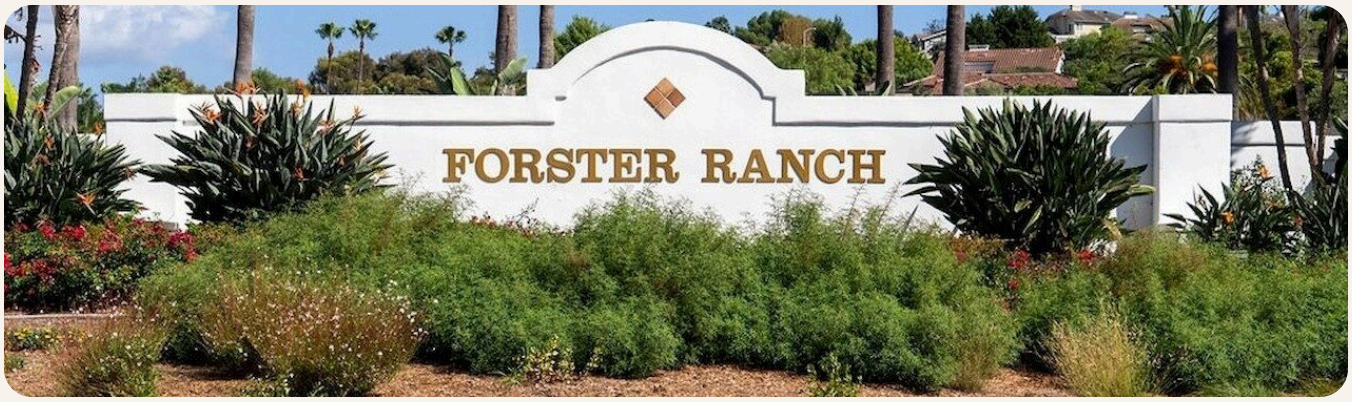
City parks nearby

Sea Summit sits on the former Marblehead Coastal property. The City lists a park in the Marblehead area. Check on a map how far it is from the specific home.

Marblehead Park (2400 Via Turqueza)

Before you buy here, check: HOA dues and rules; Special taxes or assessments; View by lot.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/sea-summit



HILLSIDE, MASTER-PLANNED

Forster Ranch

Forster Ranch is the kind of neighborhood people mean when they say they want a yard and a view without giving up the coast. It's a master-planned hillside community on the inland side of town, with winding streets and a lot of open space.

Setting	Hillside, master-planned
Walkability	Car-dependent (Redfin Walk Score about 11)
Population	Roughly 13,500 residents, per Redfin
Typical home style	Single-family homes on planned streets
Earlier price reference	Redfin: median near $1.7M in Oct. 2025
Current prices	Ask Alex for a fresh MLS pull

What people like

- More space and privacy than the coastal core
- Parks and open space built into the community plan
- Consistent, planned streets and architecture
- A short drive to the beach and Downtown

Worth knowing

- You'll drive for most errands and the beach
- HOA or assessment details vary by tract, so ask early
- Fewer vintage, one-of-a-kind homes than Downtown

City parks nearby

These city parks sit in or along the edge of Forster Ranch, one on its main boundary street, Avenida Vista Hermosa.

Forster Ranch Community Park (3207 Camino Vera Cruz) · **Vista Hermosa Sports Park** (987 Avenida Vista Hermosa) · **Jim Johnson Memorial Sports Park** (450 W. Avenida Vista Hermosa) · **Courtney's Sandcastle Universally Accessible Playground** (987 Avenida Vista Hermosa)

Before you buy here, check: HOA or assessments; Hillside factors; View and orientation.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/forster-ranch



BEACH CLUB NEIGHBORHOOD

Shorecliffs

Shorecliffs is one of San Clemente's established neighborhoods: 504 homes developed by Pacesetter Homes starting around 1960, originally single-level houses on terraced, ocean-view lots. It sits on the coastal side of the I-5, according to a local brokerage blog.

Setting	Established coastal-side neighborhood
Homes	504, per the beach club's own history
Developer	Pacesetter Homes, from about 1960
Original homes	Single-level houses on terraced, ocean-view lots
Signature amenity	The private Shorecliffs Beach Club, for residents
Not the same as	Shorecliffs Golf Club, a separate public course that shares the name

What people like

- A private beach club with a clubhouse and paddle tennis for residents
- Terraced lots with ocean outlooks on many streets
- A close-knit neighborhood identity built around the club
- A mature setting with a mix of original and remodeled homes

Worth knowing

- Homes are from the 1960s, so age, permits and systems deserve attention
- Club dues and any special assessments add to monthly costs
- View quality varies by terrace and orientation

Before you buy here, check: Beach club dues and assessments; Home age and condition; Permits for remodels.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/shorecliffs



MASTER-PLANNED, RESORT-STYLE

Talega

Talega is a different San Clemente. It's a large planned community in the northeast part of the city, built from 1999 onward, with more than 30 neighborhoods, a golf club, and its own shopping and parks.

Setting	Inland, master-planned
Construction began	1999
Planned size	About 3,500 residential units, across 3,510 acres in the specific plan
Neighborhoods	More than 30
Distance to coast	About 3 miles; about 2 miles east of I-5
Architecture	Predominantly Spanish-Tuscan style

What people like

- Parks, trails, and a golf club inside the community
- Newer construction than the coastal core
- Shopping, groceries, and services close by
- More space for the money than the beachfront blocks

Worth knowing

- About 3 miles from the coast, so beach days mean a drive
- HOA dues and possible extra assessments
- Commute times depend on I-5 traffic, so test your route at rush hour

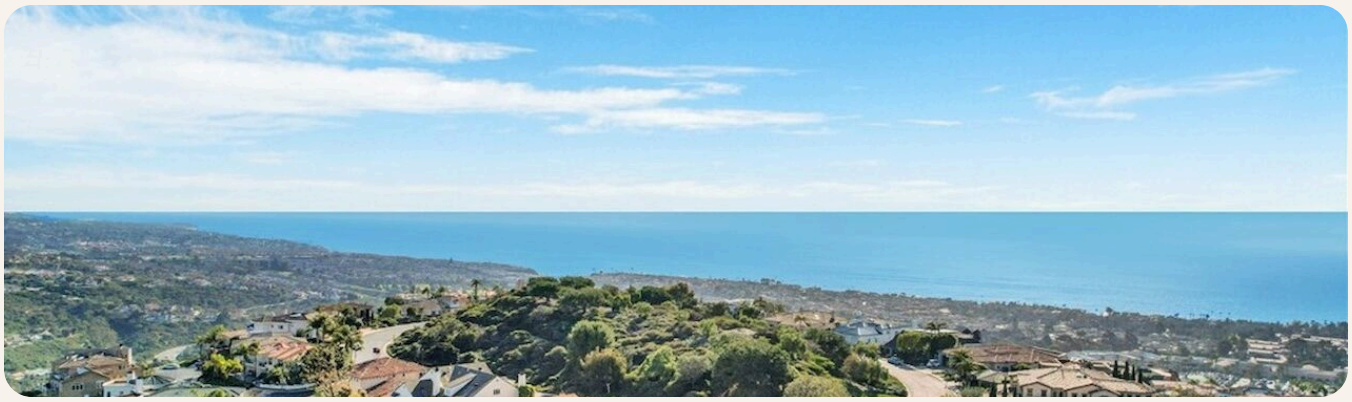
City parks nearby

The City lists these parks in Talega. HOA parks inside individual Talega tracts are separate, so ask about those too.

Talega Park (179 Corte Cristianitos) · **Liberty Park** (390 Calle Saluda) · **Tierra Grande Park** (399 Camino Tierra Grande)

Before you buy here, check: HOA dues; Special taxes or assessments; Architectural rules.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/talega



ELEVATED HILLSIDE

Rancho San Clemente

Rancho San Clemente climbs up the hillside in tiers, which is why views are such a big part of the conversation here. It's a master-planned community developed later than the historic core, with Spanish-style architecture that echoes the town's roots.

Setting	Elevated, hillside, master-planned
Development era	Later than the historic core, per local descriptions
Typical home style	Spanish-style single-family homes
Views	Vary by elevation and orientation
Current prices	Ask Alex for a fresh MLS pull

What people like

- Elevation and views
- Spanish-style design that fits the town
- A residential feel with a short drive to the coast
- Hillside streets with room to breathe

Worth knowing

- Views and prices vary widely by exact lot
- Hillside lots can mean slopes and stairs
- You'll drive to the beach and Downtown

City parks nearby

The City's park for this area is Rancho San Clemente Park, open 6 a.m. to 10 p.m. daily according to its facility page.

Rancho San Clemente Park (150 Calle Aguila)

Before you buy here, check: Orientation and view; Hillside factors; Lot and access.

Full guide: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods/rancho-san-clemente

KNOW THE REAL COST

The costs beyond the price

Two homes with the same price can cost very different amounts each month. Ask for every layer in writing before you compare.

Layer	What to know
Master HOA	Shared amenities and common areas. Dues vary widely by community
Neighborhood or sub-association	An extra HOA in some tracts, sometimes with gates or shared landscaping
Mello-Roos special tax	A separate annual tax in some communities, billed with property taxes. Ask for the amount and the end date
Property tax	Based on the purchase price, plus any local charges on the bill
Homeowners insurance	Get quotes before you remove contingencies. Coastal and hillside homes can differ
Maintenance	Roof, systems, landscaping and slopes, especially on older or larger homes

Figures we have seen (from public sources, undated, confirm for the exact home)

- **Talega:** one local guide lists a master assessment of about $267 a month, with sub-association charges bringing totals into the low-to-mid $300s, plus a separate Mello-Roos tax.
- **Sea Summit:** recent listings show HOA dues around $330 to $340 a month, plus Mello-Roos.
- **Sea Pointe Estates:** listings show roughly $425 to $480 a month for a guard-gated community.
- **Shorecliffs:** the private beach club's dues are not published, so ask.

These come from listing copy and local guides, not association documents. Always request the current budget, reserve study and any assessments.

BEFORE YOU OFFER

Your pre-offer checklist

Documents to request

- HOA budget and the latest reserve study
- CC&Rs, bylaws and rules, including architectural review
- Recent board minutes
- Any pending or recent special assessments
- Mello-Roos status, annual amount and end date
- Permit history for additions, pools and major work
- Preliminary title report

Inspect

- Roof, electrical, plumbing and a sewer-line camera on older homes
- Slopes, retaining walls and drainage on hillside lots
- Salt-air wear on windows, doors and metal near the coast

Questions to ask

- What is the total monthly cost, with every association included?
- What do the dues cover and what do they not?
- What rules affect the remodel I am planning?
- How long have comparable homes taken to sell, and at what discount?
- What could be built nearby that would change the view?
- How does the drive to work and the beach feel at the hours I would use it?

Try it yourself

- Visit at different times of day and on a weekend
- Park, walk and listen
- Look at the street in the evening

Schools: check them yourself. Attendance boundaries change and we do not rate or rank schools. Use the district's My School Locator with the exact address (capousd.org, Capistrano Unified School District), look up official results on the California School Dashboard (caschooldashboard.org) and confirm enrollment details with the district. Alex can pull the address list for any area you are considering.

San Clemente market snapshot (September 2026, single-family)

Measure	Now	A year ago	Note
Median sale price	$2,225,000	$2,085,000	Sept 2026 vs. Sept 2025 (+6.7%)
Single-family closings	43	n/a	Sept 2026 (55 across all home types)
Active single-family listings	105	130	Sept 2026 vs. Sept 2025
Months of supply	2.9	3.2	Sept 2026 vs. Sept 2025
Expected time to sell	84 days	109 days	As of Oct. 1, 2026 vs. Oct. 2025

NEXT STEPS

Let's narrow it down

Pick two or three areas from this guide, and Alex will walk you through current homes in each, with the HOA documents, recent sales and costs side by side. No pressure, no obligation.

Talk to Alex Yu

(949) 749-2946 · alex@alexyuteam.com

lifeinsanclemente.com

More local guides

- Neighborhood pages with sources: lifeinsanclemente.com/neighborhoods
- The San Clemente blog: lifeinsanclemente.com/blog
- Free home valuation: lifeinsanclemente.com/home-value

Important. This guide is general information compiled from public sources and is not legal, tax or financial advice. Figures and descriptions change and are not guaranteed. Always verify details for the specific property, including HOA, Mello-Roos, permits and flood or hazard disclosures, before you rely on them. Equal Housing Opportunity.

Alex Yu · Alex Yu Team · SERHANT · CA DRE #01492674